



ASK A PANEL

My partner is eager to rent a handheld Doppler so we can listen to our baby's heartbeat. Is this a good idea?

Doctor: Handheld ultrasound Doppler devices, which allow parents-to-be to listen to the fetal heartbeat at home, are currently sold over the counter in the US. Parents are told they can listen to their baby “in complete safety as early as 10 weeks of pregnancy” and “any time they want,” implying there is no limit on frequency of exposure.

However, there has been no research into the effects of frequent scanning, which would be more than the baby receives during prenatal care. A Doppler is not a toy and using it in this way is an unnecessary risk.

Midwife: Using your own Doppler may help reassure you if you are very anxious about your baby's well-being, but it is just as likely to have the opposite effect if you can't pick up the heartbeat. Identifying different sounds takes practice and if you have difficulty finding the heartbeat (this happens to midwives, too!), it could be distressing. If you're worried about your baby for any reason, help and advice is only a phone call away.

Mom: I used a Doppler because I am a worrier and it really gave me peace of mind. I didn't use it very often and only when there was a good reason to. For example, at one stage of my pregnancy, I had an episode of bleeding and clots. After this, I was very worried about my baby's